

# **BETWEEN FOLK TRADITION AND CLASSICAL INFLUENCE: A STUDY OF BENGALI FOLK MUSIC**

A Thesis Submitted in Partial Fulfilment of the  
Requirements for the Degree of Master of Arts  
in Instrumental Music

Submitted by

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[March, 2026]

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# DECLARATION

I hereby declare that the dissertation entitled "Raga-Like Modal Structures in Bengali Folk Music: A Theoretical Analysis" submitted to Rabindra Bharati University in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the degree of Master of Arts (M.A.) in Instrumental Music is my original work.

The study has been carried out under the guidance of my supervisor. The work presented in this dissertation has not been submitted previously, either in part or in full, for the award of any degree, diploma or certificate at any university or institution.

All sources of information used in the preparation of this dissertation have been properly acknowledged and included in the bibliography.

I further declare that this dissertation represents an honest academic effort and that no part of it has been copied from any source without appropriate acknowledgement.

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# CERTIFICATE OF THE SUPERVISOR

This is to certify that the dissertation entitled "Raga-Like Modal Structures in Bengali Folk Music: A Theoretical Analysis" has been prepared by Mr. Ankit Kar under my supervision and guidance in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the degree of Master of Arts (M.A.) in Instrumental Music, Rabindra Bharati University.

To the best of my knowledge, the work embodied in this dissertation is original and has not been submitted previously for the award of any degree, diploma or certificate of this or any other university.

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# ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

The completion of this dissertation would not have been possible without the support and encouragement of many individuals and institutions.

First and foremost, I express my sincere gratitude to my supervisor for providing valuable guidance, constructive suggestions and continuous encouragement throughout the course of this research. Their academic insight and support helped me develop a deeper understanding of the subject and complete this study successfully.

I am grateful to the Department of Instrumental Music, Rabindra Bharati University, for providing the academic environment necessary for the completion of this work. The knowledge and training received during my course of study have played a significant role in shaping my understanding of Indian music and musicology.

I would also like to acknowledge the contributions of the scholars, musicians and researchers whose published works have been consulted during the preparation of this dissertation. Their research provided important insights into the history, theory and practice of both Bengali folk music and Hindustani classical music.

I extend my heartfelt thanks to my teachers, friends and fellow students for their encouragement and valuable discussions throughout this academic journey.

Finally, I express my deepest gratitude to my family for their constant support, patience and faith in me. Their encouragement has been a source of strength and motivation at every stage of my education.

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# ABSTRACT

Bengali folk music occupies a unique position within the musical culture of India. Traditions such as Baul, Bhatiali, Bhawaiya and Kirtan have developed over centuries through oral transmission and community practice. At the same time, many listeners and musicians often notice similarities between the melodic structures of these folk traditions and the ragas of Hindustani classical music. The nature of this relationship, however, remains a subject of discussion.

This study examines whether selected Bengali folk melodies follow the grammatical principles associated with Hindustani ragas or whether they represent independent modal systems with their own musical logic. Through a comparative analysis of representative folk songs and established raga structures, the research investigates scales, melodic movement, note emphasis and characteristic phrases. Bhatkhande notation has been used wherever necessary to present and compare musical examples.

The study focuses on four important genres of Bengali folk music: Baul, Bhatiali, Bhawaiya and Kirtan. These genres have been selected because of their historical importance and their rich melodic content. The analysis reveals that while many folk melodies display features that resemble particular ragas, they often do not strictly follow the complete grammatical framework of classical raga performance. Instead, the melodic structures of Bengali folk music frequently demonstrate a flexible modal approach shaped by regional culture, performance practice and oral tradition.

Based on these observations, the dissertation proposes a simple theoretical framework for understanding Bengali folk modal structures. The study argues that Bengali folk music should not be viewed merely as a simplified form of classical music. Rather, it represents a rich musical tradition that possesses both connections to and independence from the raga system.

Keywords: Bengali Folk Music, Raga, Modal Structure, Baul, Bhatiali, Bhawaiya, Kirtan, Hindustani Classical Music.

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